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Latest Version
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Education

Ph.D. Economics, Toronto Metropolitan University, 2027 (expected)
M.A. Economics, Wilfrid Laurier University, 2021
B.Com. Economics, Toronto Metropolitan University, 2019

Fields

Applied Microeconomics, Conflict, Food Security, Indigenous and Northern Economics

References

Nicholas Li
Department of Economics
Toronto Metropolitan University
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Obeid Ur Rehman
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Angela Doku
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Vandna Sinha
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University of Colorado Boulder
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Job Market Paper

Vertical Integration in Uncompetitive Markets: Evidence from the Acquisition of North Star Air by the North West Company
(with Nicholas Li)

Canada's remote northern communities have some of the highest food prices and food insecurity rates in the world and rely on a small number of retail and transportation firms. In 2017, the largest retailer in the region, the NorthWest Company, acquired a regional airline and started transporting its own air freight to some of the "fly-in" communities it serves. Using a difference-in-difference design, we evaluate the effects of vertical integration on prices and shipment quantities of perishable foods. We find that after the acquisition, communities with vertically integrated retail-air freight experienced approximately 3.9% lower prices and 9.5% higher shipment quantities relative to comparison communities. Effects are qualitatively similar in communities where the acquisition changed firm boundaries without changing routes or upstream competition (Ontario) versus communities where it created new routes and competition (Manitoba and Nunavut). In communities where the retailer has a larger market share, its price falls by less but total community-level shipments rise by more. A theoretical model suggests that this could be due to greater "business-stealing" and lower share of sales exposed to marginal cost reductions in more competitive communities, and evidence from retailer-level shipments supports this interpretation. Our findings show that vertical integration can benefit consumers in markets with limited competition but that the size and nature of these benefits is sensitive to upstream and downstream market structure.

Working Papers

The Costs of Extreme Remoteness (with Nicholas Li)

Remoteness, defined broadly as the distance of a location from other salient locations, is associated with many negative economic outcomes. The high costs of remoteness can also affect government budgeting and motivate mitigation policies. We explore measurement of remoteness in a Canadian context and its association with economic outcomes, with a focus on food security and food prices. We find that the impact of extreme remoteness on prices and costs – for example, the case of fly-in communities with no regular road connection – is not well captured by the widely-used Statistics Canada remoteness index. But we also find that some road-connected communities have higher prices than fly-in communities, raising questions about the criteria used to determine eligibility for Nutrition North Canada, a freight subsidy that mitigates the effect of extreme remoteness on food costs. Our analysis highlights how both the measurement of remoteness and the targeting of policies to mitigate the costs of remoteness would benefit from paying closer attention to supply-chains and by leveraging additional public data on prices and freight costs.

How Foreign Investment Shapes Conflict: Evidence from Myanmar

How does foreign investment shape violence in fragile states? I study this question in Myanmar, where foreign capital expanded during a decade marked by political transition, armed conflict, and the 2021 military coup. I combine a township-year panel for 2015–2024 with sectoral foreign direct investment (FDI) approvals and pre-period employment shares to construct local shift-share measures of exposure to national FDI movements. I distinguish resource from non-resource investment and disaggregate conflict fatalities by the identities of perpetrators and victims. The aggregate relationship between FDI exposure and conflict is weak, but this masks pronounced sectoral differences. Greater resource-sector exposure is associated with less state–nonstate battlefield violence but more violence by non-state actors against civilians. By contrast, greater non-resource exposure is associated with lower fatalities overall, with the largest reductions in non-state violence against civilians. These findings suggest that the consequences of foreign investment for conflict depend not simply on how much investment arrives, but on the sectors it enters and the forms of violence it reshapes.

Work in Progress

Sustainable Human Use of the Arctic Marine Environment
(with Nicholas Li, Jackie Dawson, Lis Jorgenson and many others)

Comparative Analysis of Food Security Models and Metrics in Nunavut
(with Nicholas Li, Niksik, Tracey Galloway, Sappho Gilbert and others)

Community-Informed Modeling of Interventions to the Nutrition North Canada Subsidy Program (with Nicholas Li, Tracey Galloway, Sophie Roher and others)

Policy Reports & Other Writing

Strengthening Food Access in Nunavut: Lessons from the Inuit Child First Initiative funded Grocery Supports and the Hamlet Food Voucher Program (2026). (with Vandna Sinha and many others)

Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025 (2026). (with Vandna Sinha and many others)

Competition in the Food Supply Chain in Northern Canada (2026). (with Nicholas Li)

Research Note for NNC on Community Eligibility (2026). (with Nicholas Li)

Preliminary findings from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk, Nunavut: Technical report (2025). (with Vandna Sinha and many others)

Seminars, Conferences & Guest Lectures

University of Toronto Economics Brown Bag Seminars, 2026–Present
Toronto Metropolitan University Economics Brown Bag Seminars, 2023–Present
Qaujigiartiit Health Research Centre: Housing and Food Affordability, 2026
Toronto Metropolitan University, 2026
Balsillie School of International Affairs, 2026
Atlantic Canada Economics Conference, 2025
Chiefs of Ontario Wellness Conference, 2025
Inuit Food Sovereignty Conference, 2025

Fellowships & Awards

Toronto Metropolitan University Graduate Fellowship, 2022–2026
Toronto Metropolitan University Graduate Development Award, 2024–2025
Wilfrid Laurier University Graduate Scholarship, 2021–2022
Wilfrid Laurier University Top MRP, 2021
John & Ann Weir Economics Scholarship, 2021
Ryerson University Community Builder Award, 2016
Ryerson University Leadership Award, 2015

Teaching

Toronto Metropolitan University
Teaching/Academic Assistant for: Principles of Microeconomics, Introductory/Intermediate Macroeconomics, Intermediate Microeconomics II, Statistics for Economics II, International Trade I, Advanced Topics in International Trade, Economic Development, Labour Economics, Econometrics II, 2022–Present

Wilfrid Laurier University
Teaching Assistant for: Applied Econometrics, Macroeconomic Analysis, Statistical Methods for Life and Health Science, Advanced Calculus, Introduction to Mathematical Proofs, Calculus II, 2020–2022

Research Experience

Senior Research Assistant, TMU, for Nicholas Li, 2022–Present
Research Assistant, CU, for Vandna Sinha, 2026
Research Assistant, TMU, for Obeid Ur Rehman, 2025–2026
Research Assistant, TMU, for Jessica Penney, 2025

Skills

Stata, Python, R, GIS

Citizenship

Canada